

My Child Will Wee on the Toilet but Will Only Poo in a Nappy



A common stage

Many children who have learned to use the toilet or potty for wees still prefer to poo in a nappy. This is very common, especially between the ages of 2 and 4 years.

Why does this happen?

There is not always a clear reason. Some children:

- Are not ready to give up the last part of being a baby.
- Feel worried about the sensation of poo falling into the toilet or potty.
- Like the routine they have always known.
- Feel anxious or unsure about using the toilet for pooing.
- Have constipation, which can make pooing uncomfortable.



A helpful check

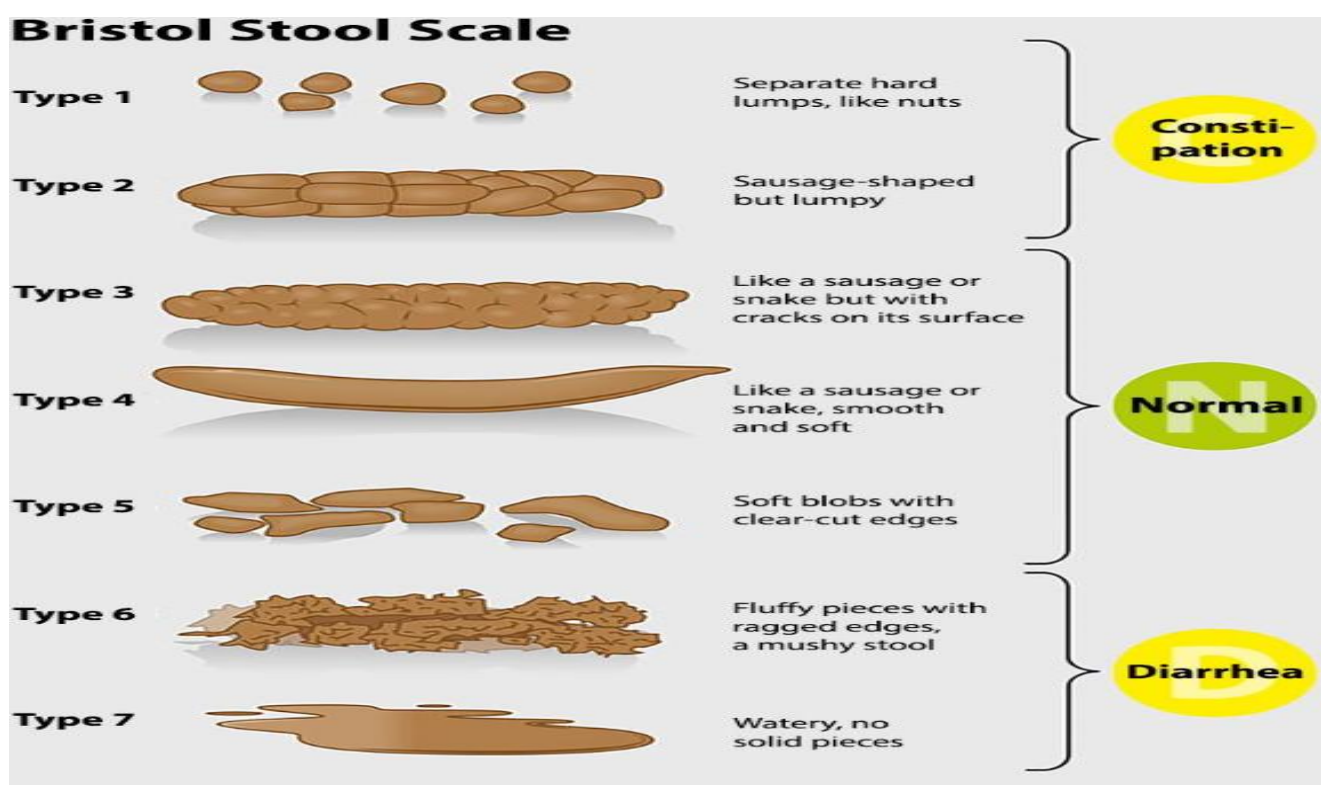
Most children who do this do not have an underlying problem. However, it is a good idea to speak to your health visitor, GP, or healthcare professional to check for constipation or any other issues.

Before you start

Understanding what can happen if nappies are stopped too soon

What happens if I stop using nappies altogether?

Some children will simply hold their poo in if they do not want to use the toilet or potty. Over time, this can lead to constipation, which can make the problem worse.



If you are worried about constipation

If you think your child is holding their poo in or becoming constipated, speak to a healthcare professional. Constipation usually needs treating before toilet training for pooing can move forward successfully.

How can I help my child learn to poo on the toilet?

The key is to make changes slowly and help your child feel in control.

Think small steps

Your child does not have to go straight from pooing in a nappy to pooing in the toilet. The steps in this guide can be introduced gradually, at a pace that feels manageable for your child.

3. TOILET LEARNING JOURNEY

Small Steps Lead to Success



Step

1 & Step 2

Build confidence without taking the nappy away too quickly

Keep using the nappy, but move it to the bathroom

- Let your child ask for a nappy when they need a poo.
- Keep the nappies in the bathroom only.
- Take them to the bathroom when they need one.
- Stay with them or provide a favourite book or toy while they poo.

1) Keep using the nappy, but move it to the bathroom

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Show where poo belongs

"Poo goes in the toilet."

- Remove the nappy straight away.
- Help empty the poo into the toilet.
- Explain simply. "Poo goes in the toilet."
- Let them flush the toilet.
- Help them wash and dry their hands.

★ Poo goes in the toilet. Flush and wash hands afterwards. ♥

2) Show where poo belongs

- After your child has finished, remove the nappy straight away.
- Encourage them to help empty the poo into the toilet.
- Explain simply: "Poo goes in the toilet."
- Let them flush the toilet.
- Help them wash and dry their hands.

Praise the process

At this stage, success means becoming comfortable with the bathroom and learning that poo belongs in the toilet. There is no need to rush.

Step 3 & Step 4

Encourage independence and introduce sitting on the toilet



3) Encourage independence

- Try to put the nappy on and take it off while your child is standing up. This helps them:
- Join in with dressing and undressing.
- Learn about wiping.
- Feel more grown up and involved.



4) Sit on the toilet or potty with the nappy on

- Once your child is happy pooing in a nappy in the bathroom, encourage them to sit on the toilet or potty while wearing the nappy.
- Start with short periods.
- Gradually increase the time until they are sitting throughout the whole poo.
- Use lots of praise and encouragement. Small rewards, such as stickers, can help motivate some children.

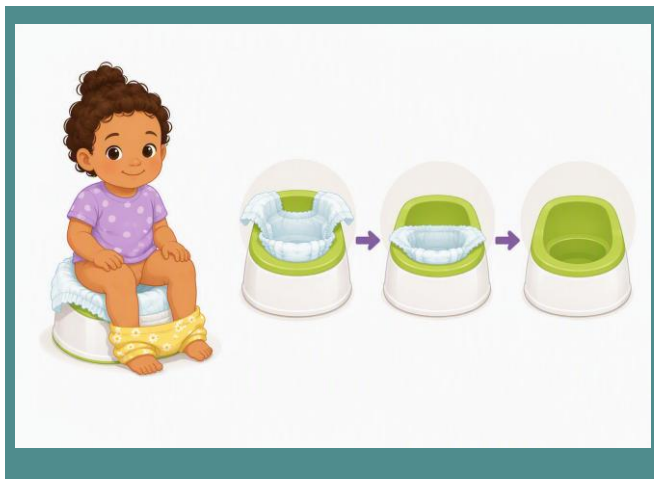
Keep it positive

The aim is to help your child feel safe, comfortable and in control while they practice a new step.

Moving from nappy to toilet

When your child is comfortable sitting on the toilet or potty with a nappy on, you can start reducing their dependence on the nappy.

Different approaches work for different children:



Use the nappy as a bridge

- Place the nappy inside the potty or under the toilet seat.
- Gradually lower it so it is not touching your child's bottom.
- Eventually remove it completely.

OR

Some children find replacing the nappy with toilet paper helpful.



Gradually use smaller nappies

- Move to smaller and smaller nappy sizes.
- Explain that there will soon be no nappies that fit.
- Encourage your child to use the toilet or potty like a "big boy" or "big girl."

Moving from nappy to toilet

Other gradual approaches



Leave the nappy undone

- Put the nappy on but do not fasten it.
- Replace it over time with kitchen roll or toilet paper.
- Gradually reduce the amount until no barrier is needed.

OR



Cut a hole in the nappy

- Start with a small hole.
- Slowly make the hole bigger over time.
- Eventually, the poo passes straight into the toilet or potty.

Choose the approach that suits your child

Different approaches work for different children. The important thing is to make changes gradually and avoid turning toilet learning into a battle.

Remember: avoid a battle of wills

Keeping toilet learning calm and positive

This issue can sometimes become stressful for parents and children. Try to:

- Stay calm and positive.
- Avoid pressure or punishment.
- Praise every small step forward.
- Be consistent with the approach you choose.
- Agree on a simple plan with everyone caring for your child.



With patience and encouragement

Most children learn to poo on the toilet or potty successfully.

What if my child has additional needs?

Children with additional needs can learn to use the toilet too, but they may need:

- More time.
- Smaller steps.
- A slower pace of change.

Some children find the bathroom environment difficult because of sensory sensitivities, such as:

- Noise from flushing.
- Bright lights.
- Smells.
- The feeling of sitting on the toilet.

If your child has autism, sensory differences, or other developmental needs, speak to your healthcare professional or occupational therapist. They may be able to suggest strategies tailored to your child's needs.

When should I seek help?

Knowing when to speak to a healthcare professional

Speak to a healthcare professional if your child:

- Seems constipated.
- Finds pooing painful.
- Regularly holds their poo in.
- Becomes distressed about pooing.
- Has ongoing difficulties despite trying these strategies.

Remember

Most children overcome this stage with time, patience, and support. The goal is to help your child feel confident, comfortable, and in control as they learn this new skill.

Every small step counts.

Parent and carer resource